



What is Real?

Approaches to Understanding Reality

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POLS 222: Slide Deck #1

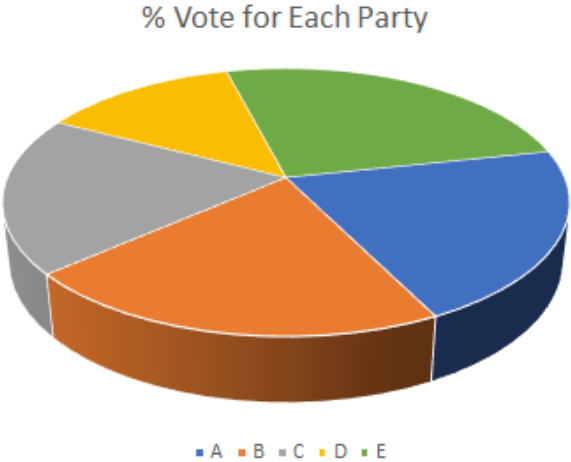
How 'foxy' are you, really?



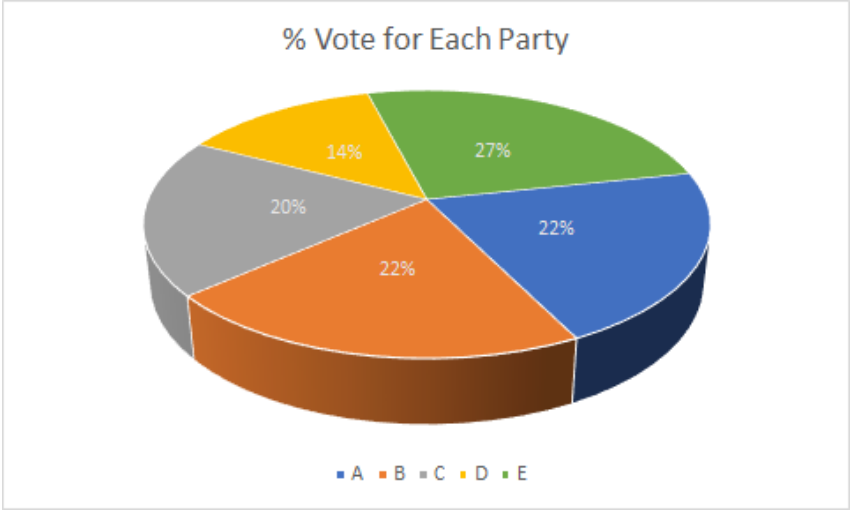
FIGURE 2-2: ATTITUDES OF FOXES AND HEDGEHOGS

How Foxes Think	How Hedgehogs Think
Multidisciplinary: Incorporate ideas from different disciplines and regardless of their origin on the political spectrum.	Specialized: Often have spent the bulk of their careers on one or two great problems. May view the opinions of “outsiders” skeptically.
Adaptable: Find a new approach—or pursue multiple approaches at the same time—if they aren’t sure the original one is working.	Stalwart: Stick to the same “all-in” approach—new data is used to refine the original model.
Self-critical: Sometimes willing (if rarely happy) to acknowledge mistakes in their predictions and accept the blame for them.	Stubborn: Mistakes are blamed on bad luck or on idiosyncratic circumstances—a good model had a bad day.
Tolerant of complexity: See the universe as complicated, perhaps to the point of many fundamental problems being irresolvable or inherently unpredictable.	Order-seeking: Expect that the world will be found to abide by relatively simple governing relationships once the signal is identified through the noise.
Cautious: Express their predictions in probabilistic terms and qualify their opinions.	Confident: Rarely hedge their predictions and are reluctant to change them.
Empirical: Rely more on observation than theory.	Ideological: Expect that solutions to many day-to-day problems are manifestations of some grander theory or struggle.
Foxes are better forecasters.	Hedgehogs are weaker forecasters.

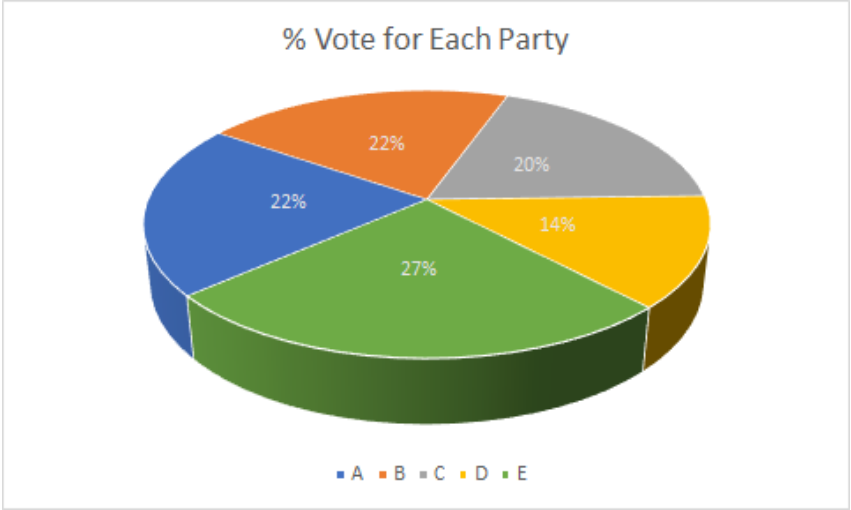
Rank the Parties from Most to Least Support



Let's Add Percentage Values...

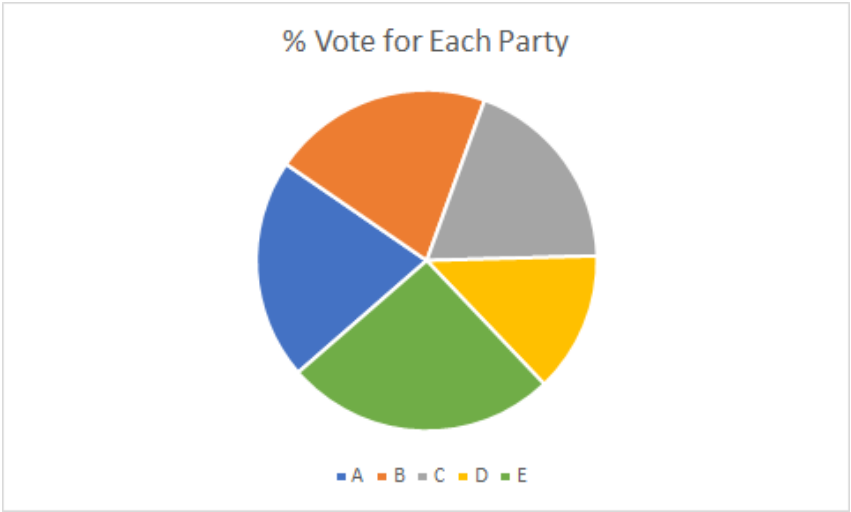


What If We Rotate the Chart?

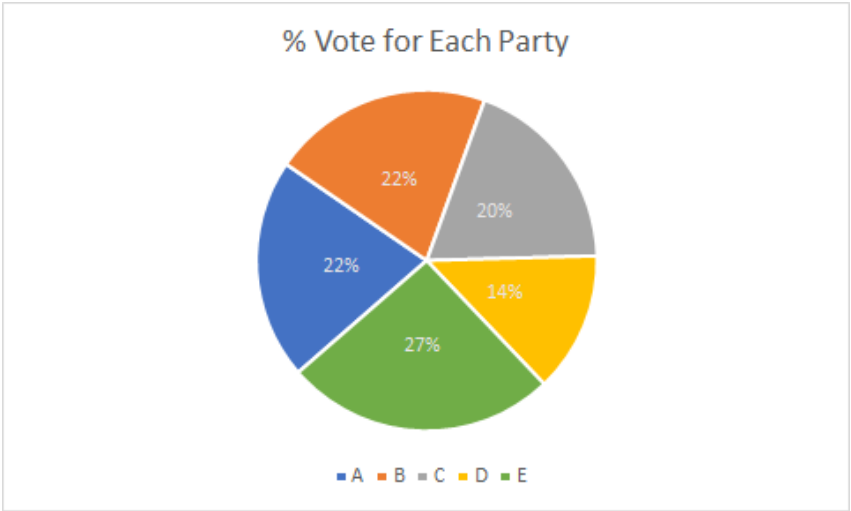


Certainly Flat Pie Charts Are Better...

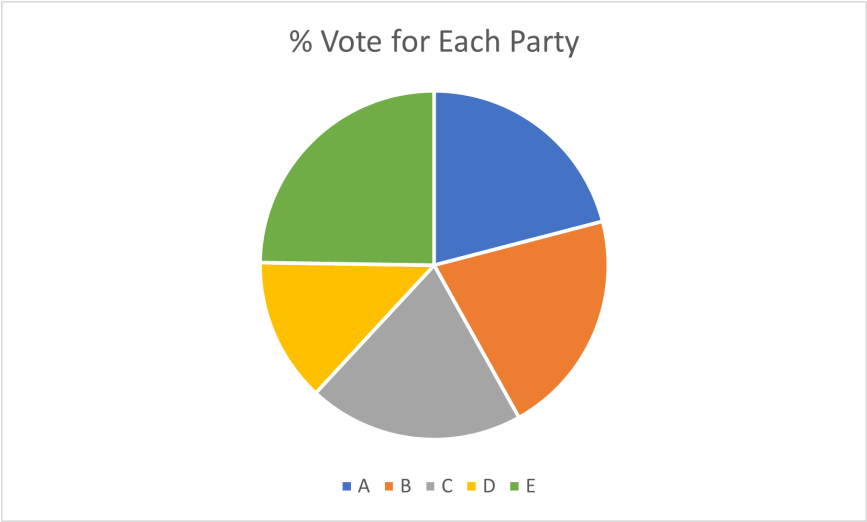
Certainly Flat Pie Charts Are Better...



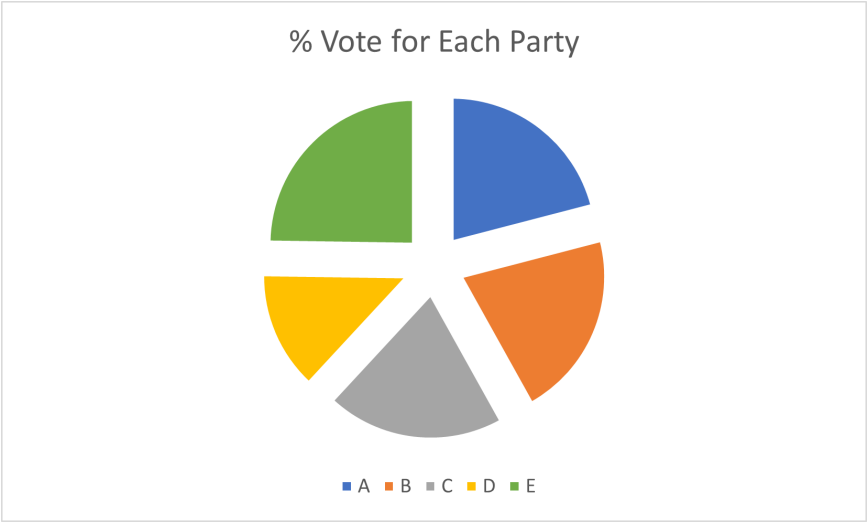
Certainly Flat Pie Charts Are Better...



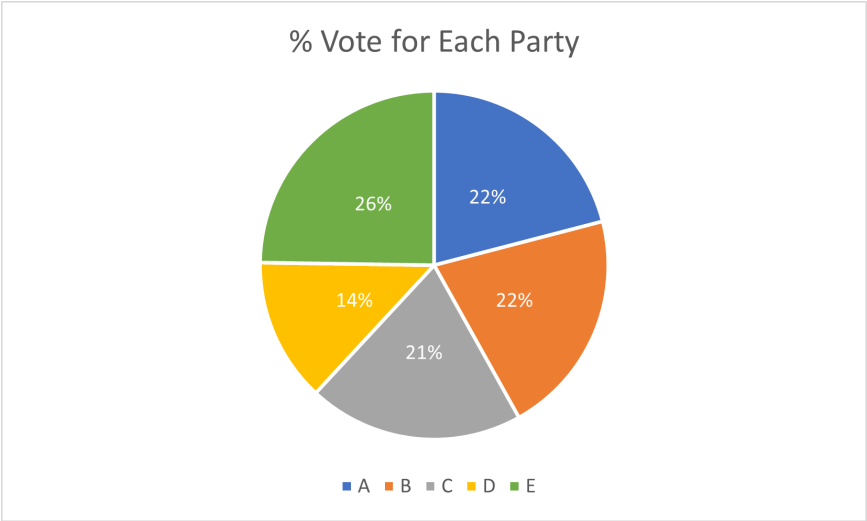
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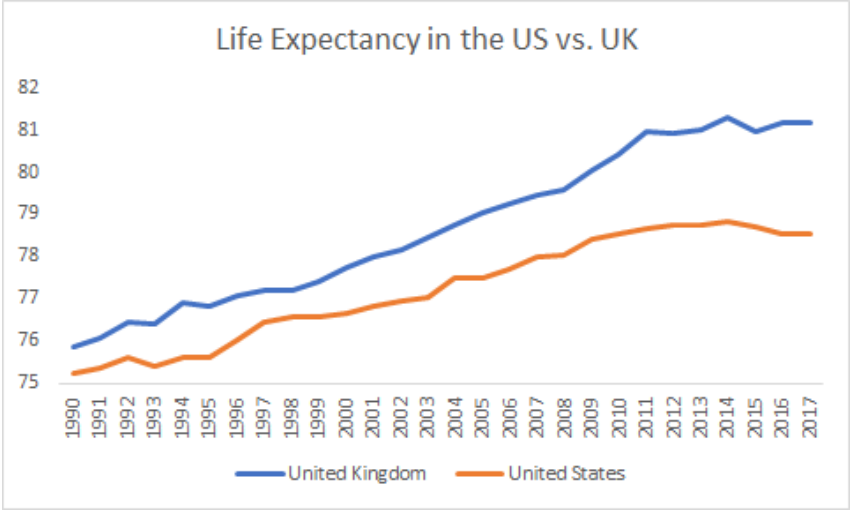
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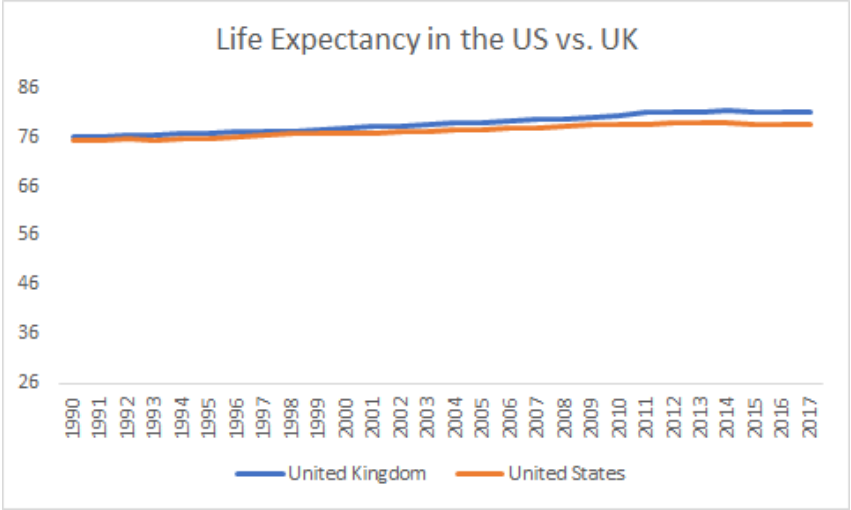
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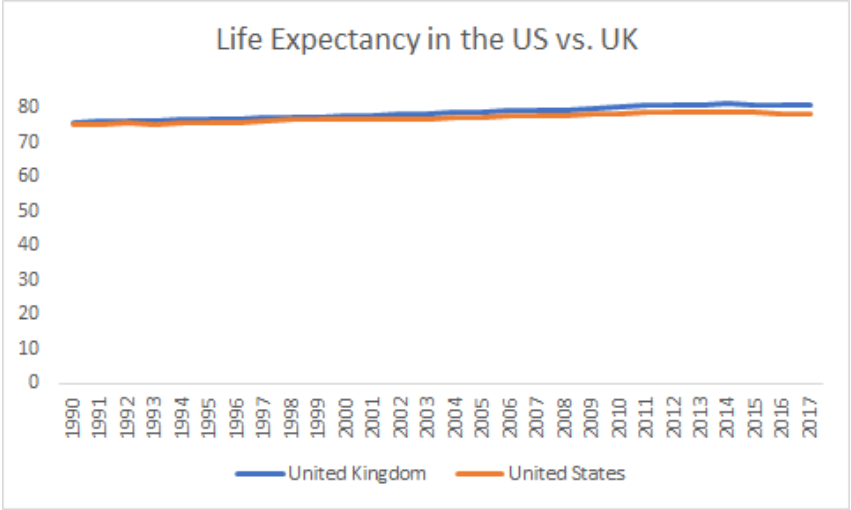
Britain Is Kicking the Shit Out of Us At Living



Maybe Not, With More Context



Shouldn't We Start At 0?



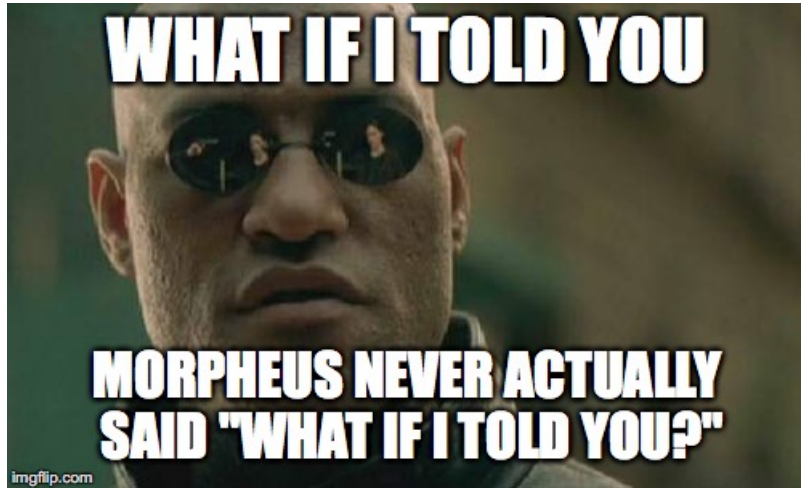
In general...

Pie charts suck. And data visualizations can be intentionally or unintentionally misleading.

Hedgehogs are great, but work on being a fox when it comes to social science and examining data:

- Be skeptical and cautious
- Tolerate complexity
- Be open to counter evidence

What is Reality?



What is Reality?

This is an ontological question.

What is the relationship between reality and subjective experience?

Premodern view:

- My subjective experience is *the* objective reality.
- e.g.: This tree is holy. Anybody who says differently is a wicked liar.

Modern view:

- Objective reality exists irrespective of my subjective experience.
- e.g.: That tree is a tree. Your interpretation of it beyond that is your own.

Postmodern view:

- Only subjective reality exists as a product of my (and others') subjective experiences.
- e.g.: There is no objective "tree," only various perspectives on tree-ness.

Take a minute to describe the current observable reality using 5 words or phrases.

Some 'ologies To Think About

Ontology: the philosophical study of being and reality.

- What exists? What is real?
- e.g.: Realism, Materialism, Idealism

Epistemology: the theory of knowledge and knowing what reality is.

- How can we know what exists and what is real?
- e.g.: Positivism, Constructivism, Interpretivism, etc.

Methodology: the approach to systematic analysis of reality.

- What is the process of knowing and learning reality?
- e.g.: Deduction, Induction, Qualitative, Quantitative, etc.

Method: the tool for systematic analysis of reality.

- What techniques are used in learning reality?
- e.g.: Case studies, stats models, process-tracing, etc.

Ontological approaches are important because they shape how we try to explain reality.

If we assume that objective reality exists outside of our subjective experiences, other questions follow:

- What is it?
- Is it knowable?
- How can we know it?

This is where epistemology comes in...

Ontology Matters

